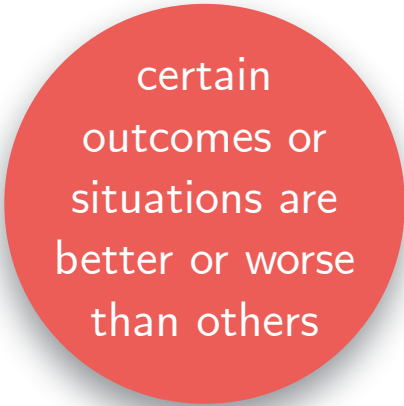




certain actions
are right or
wrong

A solid red circle with a soft drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "certain outcomes or situations are better or worse than others" is written in a white, sans-serif font, arranged in five lines.

certain
outcomes or
situations are
better or worse
than others

A solid green circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "certain people or lives are better or worse than others" is written in a white, sans-serif font, arranged in five lines.

certain
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are better or
worse than
others

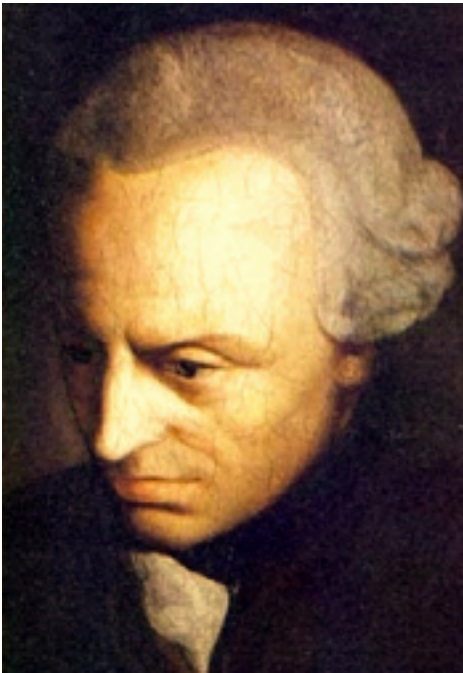
The consequentialist takes the goodness or badness of situations as fundamental, and tries to explain the others in terms of these. What would it look like if we took one of the other categories as most fundamental?

A **deontological** approach to what we ought to do takes facts about the rightness and wrongness of actions as basic, and does not try to explain the rightness or wrongness of actions in terms of the goodness or badness of the action's outcomes.

There are lots of different deontological theories. I'm going to briefly introduce you to one, which is based on the idea that people have certain basic **rights**. On this view, wrong actions are actions which violate someone's rights.

But what are rights, and which actions violate them?

One answer to this question was given by the 18th century German philosopher Immanuel Kant.



Kant thought that all human beings have dignity, and that this means that we all have the right not to be used as a way to satisfy the desires of others.

‘Act in such a way that you always treat humanity,
whether in your own person or the person of any
other, never simply as a means, but always at the same
time as an end.’

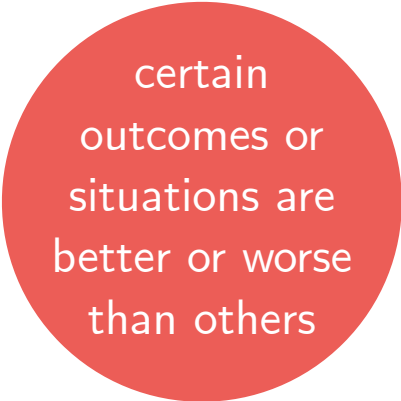
This style of deontological view might seem to give the correct account of our otherwise puzzling views of the trolley cases. It is wrong to kill David or to shove the fat man onto the tracks because those actions involve using them as a mere means to save the lives of others.

This style of deontological view is, in certain respects, much less demanding than consequentialist views. What would each theory say about the question of whether we are morally obliged to give to the poor?

By contrast, in the case where you turn the trolley to save the five, you are not using the one person on the tracks as a means to save the five; they would be saved even without them there.



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wrong

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